

Chicago Tribune



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FRIDAY, FEBRUARY 14, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

MICHAEL MADIGAN TRIAL

'Part of something really big'

Jurors reflect on their marathon deliberations, split verdict in momentous case handing corruption and bribery convictions to once-powerful speaker

By Jason Meisner, Megan Crepeau, Rebecca Johnson and Ray Long
Chicago Tribune

For more than four long months, jurors in the Michael Madigan corruption trial were strictly forbidden from researching any outside information about the landmark case they held in their hands.

But after they rendered their verdict Wednesday and the ban was lifted, a few jurors went to lunch together and started to Google. They were at Elephant & Castle near the Dirksen U.S. Courthouse, where the impact of their decision was still unfolding in the glare of the Chicago media.

Only then, according to one juror, did they realize how momentous the trial really was — the

breadth and depth of the investigation that felled the former House speaker, and the number of other players convicted or charged along the way.

"(I had) just this sense of wonder," said Juror 2, a 44-year-old woman from the west suburbs who declined to be identified publicly. "Wow, we were part of

Turn to Madigan, Page 2

Tim Nessner talks outside his Chicago home on Wednesday about his experience as foreman of the jury in former Illinois House Speaker Michael Madigan's federal corruption trial. **TERRENCE ANTONIO JAMES/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**



ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Springing into training

Cubs pitcher Gavin Hollowell jumps over a bag while outfielder Pete Crow-Armstrong puts on his cleats during spring training Thursday at Sloan Park in Mesa, Arizona. The Cubs will hold their first full-squad workout today, though most players have already reported to camp, and the team's first Cactus League game will be Thursday against the defending World Series champion Los Angeles Dodgers.



ANOTHER MISSED OPPORTUNITY: After an offseason of rumors about Alex Bregman going to the Chicago Cubs, reality set in Wednesday night with the news the free-agent third baseman agreed to a three-year, \$120 million deal with the Boston Red Sox. The swing and miss on Bregman is another chapter in a long-running narrative, writes columnist Paul Sullivan. **Chicago Sports**

Three top city officials resign

Moves come after mayor's warning to those lacking loyalty

By Jake Sheridan, Sarah Freishtat, Sam Charles and Alice Yin
Chicago Tribune

Three members of Mayor Brandon Johnson's administration announced their exits Thursday, days after the mayor delivered a warning about purging city officials who lacked loyalty to him.

Departing his cabinet are Jamie Rhee, commissioner of the Department of Aviation, and Jose Tirado, director of the Office of Emergency Management and Communications.

Separately, Joe Calvello, the mayor's chief strategy officer, stepped down this week less than a year after being hired to shore up his administration's then-struggling communications effort and build out the freshman mayor's long-term vision.

And Andrea Kersten, head of the Civilian Office of Police Accountability, also announced

Turn to Resign, Page 4

Suburbs smoking out hemp products

Without Illinois-wide rules, some ban items that can get users high

By Robert McCoppin
Chicago Tribune

In a family-friendly suburb northwest of Chicago, local officials were worried about a proliferation of shops selling hemp products that can get users high. One smoke shop in Rolling Meadows moved in next to a Dunkin' Donuts. Two more are down the street from a middle school.

Because hemp products are largely unregulated, the shops faced no restrictions on the age of their customers or the amount



Cheryl Cryer, owner of Urban Apothecary in Batavia, says CBD gummies make up 45% of her sales, but some proposed municipal legislation would limit her business. **STACEY WESCOTT/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

they can buy. The shops also aren't required to test and report on their products' potency, or the impurities they contain.

Citing safety concerns, particularly for kids, Mayor Lara Sanoica and the City Council approved a ban on the retail sale of products containing hemp-derived THC, a psychoactive compound that gets users high. The ban took effect this month.

"The evidence is clear that these substances can cause serious side effects but does not yet support that they are an effective treatment for any illness or condition," she said at the time.

In the absence of strong state and federal regulations, suburbs from Waukegan to Orland Park, and Highland Park to Elk Grove

Turn to Hemp, Page 4

Trump's reciprocal tariff order comes with risks

By Josh Boak
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — President Donald Trump rolled out his plan Thursday to increase U.S. tariffs to match the tax rates that other countries charge on imports, possibly triggering a broader economic confrontation with allies and rivals as he hopes to eliminate trade imbalances.

"I've decided for purposes of fairness that I will charge a reciprocal tariff," Trump said in the Oval Office at the proclamation signing. "It's fair to all. No other country can complain."

Trump's Republican administration has insisted that its new tariffs would equalize the ability of U.S. and foreign manufacturers to compete, although under

current law these new taxes would likely be paid by American consumers and businesses either directly or in the form of higher prices.

The politics of tariffs could easily backfire on Trump if his agenda pushes up inflation and grinds down growth, making this a high-stakes wager for a president eager to declare his authority over the U.S. economy.

The tariff increases would be customized for each country, with the partial goal of starting new trade negotiations. But other nations might also feel the need to respond with their own tariff increases on American goods. As a result, Trump may need to find ways to reassure consumers

Turn to Tariffs, Page 8

KENNEDY APPROVED: Congress confirmed Robert F. Kennedy Jr. as health secretary Thursday, putting the vaccine skeptic in control of vaccine policy, food safety and a trillion-dollar budget. **Nation & World**

CPS hires financial adviser

An independent firm has been asked to provide an outside opinion on the district's daunting economic challenges. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

United HQ on the move?

Chicago-based airline playing coy about its plans for a 113-acre site it purchased near the Denver airport late last year for \$33 million. **Business**

TODAY'S WEATHER High 26 Low 24

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 12

\$4.00 city and suburbs and elsewhere
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